



REFUGEES TOOK SHELTER IN CAMPS AT PURANA QILA IN NEW DELHI

COURTESY: ROLL BOOKS

us to rethink Partition myths, to re-examine not just the actions of individuals, but also what Partition actually meant in terms that go beyond the standard epic of Hindu, Muslim and Sikh fratricide. It is beyond time to come to a more politically mature and historically accurate appraisal of Jinnah, of Patel and Nehru, as also to appreciate more clearly the central historical challenge these towering political personalities faced and managed only partially and imperfectly to resolve—how to enable human difference and social diversity to flourish? It remains a question to us, as pointed as ever.

To kick away the old stories, we first have to escape the belief in Indian exceptionalism—that somehow our history was uniquely defined, say by the character of Hindu-Muslim relations. This involves a double move: restoring Jinnah to Indian history, and resituating Indian history in the frame of world history.

India's Partition can't be understood divorced from its global context: one of the most chaotic, uncertain, and unnerving periods of modern history. In the late 1930s and '40s, war raged across Europe and Asia, empires were collapsing, states were being conquered. New territorial entities were being imagined, from the Thousand Year Reich to the Greater East Asian Co-Prosperity Sphere to, after 1945, the United Nations and the European

Community. The contagion of nationalism was the cause of this turbulence.

The flipside of nationalism was the problem of the minority: how to deal with cultural and social differences. Empires, by definition, ruled over culturally and socially mixed people; their territories were aligned not to religious or linguistic identities, but through allegiance to an overarching symbol or idea. As empires retreated or were defeated, the spreading model of the nation-state tried to bring cultural and social identity into alignment with territory. The transition occasioned much blood-letting, and generated the terminology of genocide, ethnic cleansing, and of Partition.

With the end of World War II, two broad responses to the problem of the minority emerged. The first saw territory, the creation of states, as the most reliable way of securing minority rights—a minority could become a majority within its own borders. The second invoked law—constitutional, and in particular international law of human rights, newly minted in the after-war years, as a way of protecting minority identities within national territories.

On the Indian subcontinent, the problem of the minority, and the respective merits of such responses were vigorously debated. Dr B.R. Ambedkar, for instance, in his striking 1940 essay on 'Pakistan or The Partition of India', invoked les-